

Culture-Based Dating App — Full Product Blueprint

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Vision & Positioning

The app matches people on how they think and what they love — humor style and musical taste — before it shows them a face. Target users: Gen Z and young millennials burned out on photo-first swiping who want proof of compatibility before the first message.

Core promise: every match starts from a shared laugh or a shared track, never a profile photo alone.

Positioning against the field:

- vs. Schmooze — memes *and* music together, so humor-only false positives (funny but sonically incompatible) get filtered out
- vs. Turn Up / Vinyly — a genuinely free core loop; no paywall on seeing likes or sending messages
- vs. Boo — signals people generate every day (swipes, plays), not a one-time personality quiz that goes stale

Working name: not yet decided — "Cultured" is used as a placeholder below wherever a name is needed.

Competitive Landscape: What Works, What Doesn't

No incumbent combines memes and music without a fatal flaw — that gap is the opening.

Platform	Mechanism	Strength	Fatal flaw
Schmooze	AI meme-swipe humor profile	Frictionless icebreakers, strong female retention, viral sharing	Intent dilution — casual meme-browsers flooded the dating pool, forcing a UI split

Platform	Mechanism	Strength	Fatal flaw
Turn Up	Gamified music profiles, blind-test quiz	Dual date/friend modes, interactive icebreaker	Punitive paywall on likes and message delivery kills the free-tier network
Vinyllly	Passive Spotify history	Zero-effort profile, concert-proximity matching	Purely passive — not enough daily engagement to sustain habit
Boo	MBTI personality quiz	Deep psychological framing, engaged niche community	Freemium-to-paywall bait-and-switch; weak moderation, scammer complaints

Design rules this forces on us:

1. Bifurcate content browsing from partner evaluation from day one — never let Schmooze's mistake happen at all
2. Never gate seeing likes or sending a first message — Turn Up and Boo both lost the free-tier network this way
3. Give the Culture Feed a genuine daily-engagement loop — don't repeat Vinyllly's passivity
4. Bake in identity verification from the start — Boo's scammer problem is a trust issue, not a feature gap

Brainstormed Feature Ideas (Beyond the Research)

Ideas the source report didn't cover, organized by what they'd do for the product.

Deepen the cultural signal

- *Taste Twins score* — a single 0–100 compatibility number shown on a match card, built from the humor + music cosine similarity, so people don't have to infer fit from a wall of tags
- *Meme caption duels* — both users caption the same meme independently before a match unlocks; captions reveal side by side as an icebreaker with built-in comedic tension

- *Concert & event radar* — surfaces matches who follow the same artist and have an upcoming show in the user's city (extends Vinyly's concert idea into an active prompt, not a static field)
- *Anti-genre filter* — let users flag genres/humor styles they actively dislike (not just likes), since the research notes aggressive humor and mismatched taste predict *incompatibility*, not just weak affinity

Make the Culture Feed stickier without diluting intent

- *Daily Drop* — one curated meme + one curated track pushed each morning, reacting to it feeds the vector model even on days a user isn't actively browsing
- *Squad remix* — users can remix a friend's shared meme with their own caption and re-share, a lightweight creation loop instead of pure consumption
- *Taste evolution timeline* — a private, opt-in view of how a user's humor/music vectors shifted over months (nostalgia + engagement hook, never shown to matches)

Reduce first-message anxiety further

- *Vibe-check voice notes* — a 10-second audio reaction to a shared track, lower effort than typing, higher signal than a like
- *Co-listen countdown* — schedule a Listening Session for later today instead of requiring both users online now, with a calendar-style reminder
- *Icebreaker roulette* — auto-suggested opener built from the single most-overlapping niche meme or artist, shown only if the user is stuck for 30+ seconds on a new match

Trust, safety and quality

- *Vibe-report, not just block* — a lightweight "this didn't feel like a match" signal (distinct from abuse reporting) that quietly recalibrates the algorithm without punishing the reported user
- *Verified Fingerprint badge* — separate from photo verification: confirms the music/meme data is linked to a real, aged account (not bot-generated engagement)

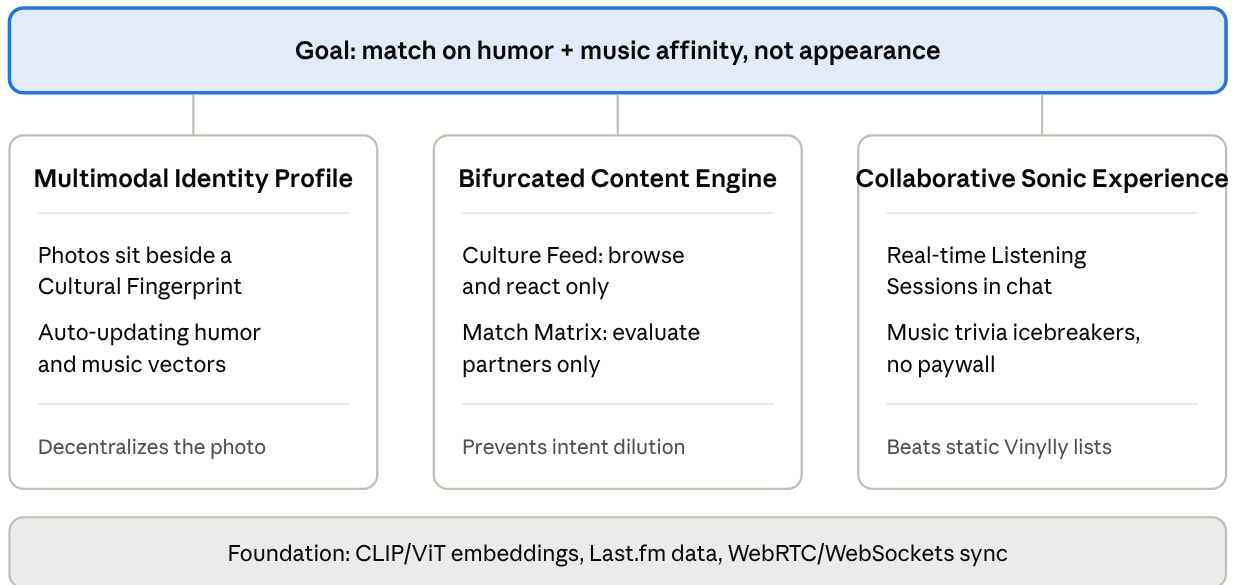
Monetization adjacent (beyond the base hybrid model)

- *Playlist Pass* — a one-time purchase to unlock unlimited co-listening session length (free tier caps sessions at e.g. 15 minutes)
- *Meme Pack drops* — limited-time, artist- or creator-licensed meme/sticker packs sold as cosmetic IAPs, doubling as a legitimate, pre-licensed revenue-safe content source (sidesteps the copyright grey zone entirely)

- *Compatibility deep-dive report* — a paid, detailed breakdown of *why* two matched users scored highly (humor style match, shared micro-genres) — a premium version of the Taste Twins score

Core Architecture: Three Pillars

Three pillars turn cultural signals into matches, not photos



three pillars · profile, content engine, sonic experience

Every interaction in the Culture Feed updates a user's humor and music vectors, which the Match Matrix reads from — the three pillars are one continuously-updating system, not three separate features.

Screen: Onboarding & Verification

Flow, in order:

1. **Welcome carousel** (3 slides) — pitches the Cultural Fingerprint concept before asking for anything: "Match on your humor, not your headshot."
2. **Phone/email + age gate** — standard auth, plus mandatory 18+ check
3. **Photo verification** — real-time selfie liveness check against later-uploaded profile photos (directly answers Boo's scammer/impersonator problem)

4. **Spotify Connect (optional but pushed)** — OAuth only, used once to pull top artists/tracks; skippable, with manual genre-tag selection as the fallback
5. **Meme calibration swipe** — 15–20 quick meme swipes (like/skip) before any profile fields, seeding the initial humor vector cold-start
6. **Music calibration** — 10 short (7-second) audio clips across genres, swipe to react; seeds the initial music vector alongside the Last.fm cross-reference
7. **Photos & video prompt** — 2–6 photos, one optional 10-second video prompt, presented as equal-weight to the Cultural Fingerprint, not the hero element
8. **Bio + basics** — name, age, location, gender/orientation preferences, looking-for (dating vs. also-open-to-friends, echoing Turn Up's dual mode)
9. **Notification & location permission asks** — last, after value is already shown

Design intent: verification and calibration come *before* the traditional bio fields, so the algorithm has real signal the moment a user reaches the Match Matrix — no cold-start blank profile.

Screen: Cultural Fingerprint (Profile)

The profile is a **split-screen tab view**, not one long scroll:

- **Photos tab** — standard image/video carousel, verification badge shown as a small check, not a giant banner
- **Fingerprint tab (default landing tab)** — the differentiator:
 - Humor style radar (affiliative / self-enhancing / aggressive / self-defeating), auto-computed, shown as a small radar chart with a one-line plain-language summary ("leans affiliative and self-enhancing") rather than raw scores
 - Top 5 artists + top 3 genres, pulled live from Spotify/Last.fm, auto-refreshing
 - 3 pinned playlists, playable inline (30-second previews, full playback requires the app or a linked streaming account)
 - "Recently vibed with" — the last 5 memes the user reacted to, shown as thumbnails (their own curation, not raw activity log)
 - Taste Twins score preview — grayed out, "unlocks when you match"
- **Prompts tab** — 3 of 8 optional text/audio prompts ("a movie I'll defend to the death," "my most-played song when I was 16") — deliberately cultural, not generic ("my ideal Sunday")

Edit mode: users can unpin/repin playlists and memes manually, overriding the auto-curation — control matters for a profile people will revisit often.

Privacy control: a single toggle — "show my Fingerprint to matches only" vs. "visible before matching, in Discovery previews."

Screen: Culture Feed

An infinite-scroll, TikTok-style vertical feed. **No profile-evaluation UI ever appears here** — that separation is the whole point (see Competitive Landscape).

Card types, interleaved:

- Meme cards — like, laugh-react (a distinct reaction from generic "like," mapped to the humor-style model), comment, share-with-caption to a match or a Culture Feed "Squad"
- Track cards — 15-second preview, save-to-Fingerprint, "who else vibes with this" tap-through
- Daily Drop card — pinned to the top once per day, one meme + one track, higher weight in the vector update
- Local Discovery card (opt-in) — "3 people near you liked this exact meme" with a soft CTA into the Match Matrix, never an inline swipe

Sharing mechanic: sharing a meme to a match/friend opens a caption composer; the sent asset is watermarked only when shared *externally* (Instagram/WhatsApp), never when shared in-app.

Explicit non-features: no swipe-to-judge-a-person gesture anywhere on this tab, no "who liked you" prompt, no match-suggestion carousel — all of that lives only in the Match Matrix.

Screen: Match Matrix

Deliberately elegant, calmer visual language than the Culture Feed (per the research's Schmooze-redesign lesson) — think Hinge's pacing, not TikTok's.

Card anatomy (single-candidate stack, not a grid):

- Photo/video, name, age, distance — standard
- **Taste Twins score badge** — top corner, e.g. "87% cultural match"

- One shared-artist chip + one shared-meme-category chip surfaced automatically as the built-in icebreaker hook
- Expand to see the full Fingerprint tab (radar, playlists, prompts) before deciding — no forced blind swiping

Actions: like, pass, super-like ("Resonate" — limited daily uses, free), rewind (premium)

Enhanced Profile Discovery: tapping a shared niche meme or artist from a card opens a filtered sub-list — "12 local singles who also loved this" — turning any single piece of content into its own matchmaking entry point

Dual mode toggle (top of screen, persistent): Dating / Friends — mirrors Turn Up's split, but shares one underlying Fingerprint and algorithm, just a different candidate pool and card copy ("looking to date" vs. "looking to vibe")

Empty state: never a blank "no more profiles" screen — falls back to "come back to the Culture Feed, your Fingerprint gets stronger the more you're there," reinforcing the feedback loop instead of feeling like a dead end.

Screen: Chat & Listening Sessions

Standard chat — text, image, one shared meme auto-attached from the match moment (the meme or track that triggered Enhanced Profile Discovery, if any) so the first message never starts from zero.

Listening Session (chat header icon):

1. Either user picks a track or a short shared playlist
2. WebSocket signaling syncs playback state (play/pause/seek) across both devices; WebRTC is reserved for the rare case both want live voice alongside it
3. Waveform scrubber visible to both, reactions (emoji burst) can be dropped at a timestamp during playback
4. Session auto-logs to the match's private "Our Soundtrack" — a running list of tracks they've listened to together, viewable only by the two matched users
5. Free tier: sessions cap at 15 minutes; **Playlist Pass** (IAP) removes the cap

Music trivia icebreaker: either user can launch a 5-question blind-test quiz built from tracks both Fingerprints share — no paywall, capped at 2 free plays/day to control server cost, unlimited on premium

Co-listen scheduling: "Listen together at 8pm?" quick-reply chip creates a mutual calendar-style reminder inside the chat, no external calendar integration needed for v1.

Screen: Notifications & Activity

One combined tab, three sections:

- **Matches & messages** — standard, new match at top with the auto-attached shared meme/track visible in the preview
- **Culture Feed activity** — someone commented on your shared meme, your Squad remixed your post, a friend saved a track you posted (kept separate from match activity so romantic and social notifications never blur together)
- **Fingerprint updates** — light, dismissible nudges only: "Your humor profile just got sharper" after calibration milestones — never guilt-trip / re-engagement dark patterns ("3 people are waiting for you!")

Push notification categories are separately toggleable in settings: new matches, messages, Feed activity, Daily Drop, marketing — matches and messages default on, everything else defaults off.

Screen: Settings & Account

- **Discovery preferences** — age range, distance, gender/orientation, Dating/Friends default mode
- **Cultural data controls** — reconnect/disconnect Spotify, manually edit genre tags, wipe and rebuild humor vector (a genuine reset, not just cosmetic), export my Fingerprint data
- **Anti-genre filters** — the "never show me" list from the brainstorm section, editable here
- **Privacy** — Fingerprint visibility toggle, incognito browsing mode (premium), block/report management, read-receipts toggle (premium feature, off by default even when subscribed)
- **Verification** — re-run photo verification, view verification badge status
- **Subscription & billing** — current tier, manage Playlist Pass / Meme Pack purchases, restore purchases

- **Safety Center** — direct links to reporting, a plain-language explainer of the repeat-infringer/moderation policy, and a one-tap “share my date’s profile with a friend” safety feature
- **Notification preferences** — per-category toggles (see Notifications screen)
- **Account** — deactivate (soft, reversible) vs. delete (hard, with the standard cooling-off window)

Monetization Model & Premium Tiers

Hybrid model: the core loop (Culture Feed, Match Matrix, matching, basic messaging) stays entirely free, permanently — no gating likes or messages, unlike Turn Up/Boo.

Tier	Price point	What it unlocks
Free	\$0	Full Feed + Matrix, unlimited basic messages, 2 free trivia plays/day, 15-min Listening Sessions, 1 Resonate super-like/day
Premium (subscription)	Monthly/annual	Read receipts, unlimited Resonates, unlimited Listening Session length, rewind, priority visibility (“SuperVibes”), incognito browsing, unlimited trivia
Playlist Pass (IAP)	One-time or per-session	Removes the 15-min Listening Session cap without a full subscription
Meme Pack drops (IAP)	Per-pack, cosmetic	Licensed meme/sticker packs for the Culture Feed — legitimately licensed, sidesteps the meme copyright grey zone entirely, and doubles as a revenue-safe content source
Compatibility deep-dive (IAP)	Per-match	A detailed “why you scored 87%” breakdown for one match

Why this split: Gen Z favors micro-transactions over subscriptions (per the research), so IAPs carry the impulse-revenue load while the subscription carries recurring “power user” perks — neither one gates a core social function.

Growth & Virality Engine

- **Watermarked external shares** — every meme shared out of the Culture Feed to Instagram/WhatsApp carries a subtle logo + "find who else relates to this on [App]" CTA, turning consumption into acquisition (Schmooze's PLG playbook)
- **Squad remix loop** — remixing and re-sharing a friend's meme spreads the app inside existing friend groups, not just romantic prospects — widens the funnel to people not yet ready to date but happy to browse
- **Concert & event radar** — pushes real-world, shareable moments ("3 matches are going to the same show") that naturally generate social-media-worthy content
- **Waitlist-gated city launch** — launch one or two dense, culturally-online cities first (university towns are a strong first bet) to avoid the "dry wasteland" effect Turn Up suffered from with too few, too spread-out users
- **Campus/creator ambassador seeding** — meme-page and music-community creators seeded with the Meme Pack IAP for their own content, driving both content quality and awareness at launch

Technical Architecture Summary

- **Client:** React Native (cross-platform), so the same WebRTC/WebSocket stack serves iOS and Android
- **Music data:** hybrid — Spotify OAuth used only for initial top-artist/track pull at signup; Last.fm Web Services 2.0 is the primary engine for genre tags, recommendations, and ongoing enrichment (Spotify's Extended Quota Mode requires 250k+ MAU, an impossible cold-start ask for a new app)
- **Real-time sync:** WebSockets (Socket.IO) for signaling, session state, and chat; WebRTC reserved for peer-to-peer audio/video when both users opt into live voice during a Listening Session
- **Matching embeddings:** Vision Transformer (ViT) or ResNet for meme image features, Sentence-BERT for on-meme text (OCR), CLIP for joint image+text vector space; LightFM-style collaborative filtering over Last.fm genre vectors; cosine similarity across both spaces drives the Match Matrix ranking
- **Rate-limit handling:** Last.fm's ~2 req/sec cap requires aggressive backend caching and async fetching — not a blocker, but a sizing input for infra planning

- **Data model note:** humor and music vectors update on every Feed interaction, so the pipeline needs to support frequent, cheap incremental updates rather than periodic batch recomputation

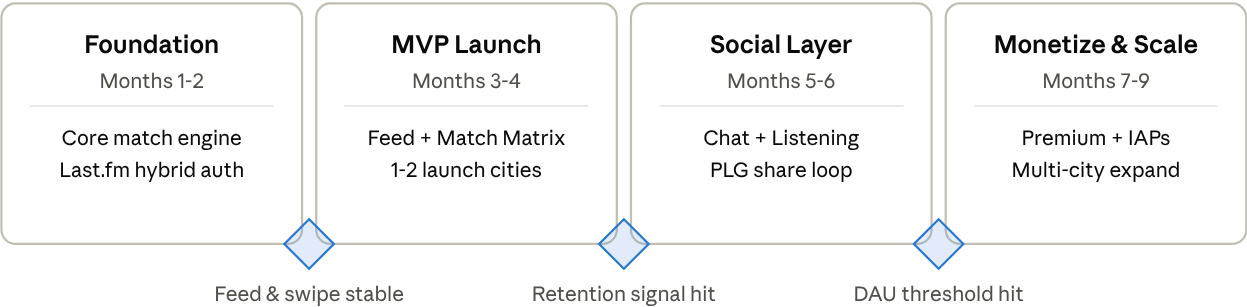
Legal & Trust Safeguards

- **DMCA Safe Harbor** — register a Copyright Agent with the U.S. Copyright Office before any user content goes live (protection is not retroactive); implement notice-and-takedown and a documented repeat-infringer policy from day one
- **User memes stay user-generated content** — the app never uses third-party copyrighted memes in its own marketing; only the licensed Meme Pack drops are used externally
- **No direct financial benefit tied to specific infringing content** — the ranking/recommendation algorithm must not be shown to specifically promote flagged content, to preserve Safe Harbor eligibility
- **Identity verification is mandatory, not optional** — directly answers Boo's scammer/impersonator complaints; liveness-checked selfie required before a profile is visible in the Match Matrix
- **Moderation policy published in-app** (Safety Center) — plain-language, not buried in a ToS document

(This section reflects the source research's legal analysis and is not legal advice — a licensed attorney should review DMCA registration and content policy before launch.)

Phased Rollout Roadmap

Four phases take the roadmap from prototype to multi-city launch



4 phases · 3 gates, prototype to multi-city launch

Each gate is a go/no-go check, not a fixed date — the next phase doesn't start on the calendar, it starts once the prior phase's signal is real.